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Leadership and Command Experience

'Good leaders command respect and not demand it; respect has to be earned,' my grandfather told me once, as he rambled on about British officers of his time. 'All of them were not the same,' he said. And I understood what he meant. As I went along in my military career, the import of what he said became crystal clear to me; to be held in high regard by one's subordinates is achievable only by dint of an officer's hard work, sincerity, professional acumen and a caring attitude. And the soldiers are the best judges of their leaders.

One can find a number of books and manuals dedicated to leadership in the armed forces. Therefore, I have no intention of traversing that broad canvas here. What I wish to do is to share my perceptions of what I saw, learnt and most importantly, practised, in my life. Fundamentally, military leadership is akin to leadership in the civil domain, be it government service or the corporate sector, except for three major differences. First, there is the question of national honour – the military has to remember that there is no silver medal in war, or to use the caption of my interview in *The Economic Times, Corporate Dossier* of 16 September 2005, 'You're No. 1 or You're Dead' (see Appendix 7). Second, human lives are at stake when a military command is given. And third, a small action can lead to catastrophic damage or embarrassment for the nation.

The raison d'etre for an army is to defend the nation and when challenged, to fight and win the war. Therefore, we have no option but to achieve victory every time the clarion call beckons us. So, for me the credo has been that of a 'warrior and a winner' – a warrior whose cause is just, and whose path is righteous. But for this to